



Epigraphic harvest at the Dead Sea: a bilingual Graeco-Aramaic inscription and other Christian epitaphs from Zoora in Palaestina Tertia

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Epigraphic harvest at the Dead Sea:
a bilingual Graeco-Aramaic inscription
and other Christian epitaphs from Zoora
in Palaestina Tertia*

Since the publication of the first three volumes of *Inscriptions from Palaestina Tertia*, which focus on the rich Greek and Aramaic material from Zoora (Ġawr al-Šāfi, al-Karak Governorate, southern Jordan),¹ new inscribed funerary monuments have been discovered in the Byzantine necropolis of the city.² The vigilant watch of Mutah University scholars made it possible to study some of them in 2022 and 2023. The present article brings to light seven unpublished tombstones whose epitaphs provide additional information on the funerary traditions, onomastics, and culture of the local society. Besides six common stelae inscribed in Greek (nos. 2-7), a more original item (no. 1) bears an exceptional bilingual Graeco-Aramaic epitaph dated 417 AD. This document is an unexpected and early witness to the use of the Syriac script in the southern part of the Byzantine Near East.

■ 1/ BILINGUAL GRAECO-ARAMAIC EPITAPH
OF OUMMABIE, DAUGHTER OF KAIAAMOS

The monument that bears our first epitaph is now in the collection of Mutah University. This tombstone made of creamy white sandstone, almost oval, and chipped in its upper part is currently 70 cm high, 35 cm wide, and 8 cm thick (Figure 1). On its front side, the surface of the stone has been carefully smoothed to receive a bilingual epitaph and a rather elaborate red painted decoration. A

sun-disc with a four-dot square pattern is outlined in the upper part of the stele. In the middle part, two sinuous snakes are represented in upright position on either side of a ten-line Greek inscription. The one on the left has smooth skin, while the one on the right is bristling with spikes turned to the right. The vertical red band below the text may belong to a cross, the horizontal bar of which would have vanished over time.

The inscription is engraved in 0.8 to 1.5 cm high letters. Lines 1, 4, 7, and 10 are also highlighted with red paint. Horizontal strokes appear above the word ἐτῶν in line 6, above all numerals in lines 6-9, and above the abbreviated divine name in line 8. Two dots are engraved on either side of the iotas of Καΐαμου and τῖα in lines 3 and 7. A small cross between two sets of three opposing chevrons adorns the end of last line. There is no difficulty in reading the text (Figure 2).

Εἰς Θεός, ἀμήν.
Μνημῖον Ουμμά-
βιης Καΐαμου, τοῦ
4/ βίου παυσομένη
μετὰ καλοῦ ὀνό-
ματο[ς] ἐτῶν λ',
ἐν ἔτι τῖα, μηνὶ
8/ Δύστρου λ', ἡμ(έρα) Κ(υρίου)υ
ς', θάρσει, οὐδὲς
ἀθάνατος. †

L. 2. μνημῖον for μνημεῖον. L. 4. παυσομένη for παυσαμένης.
L. 7. ἔτι for ἔτει. L. 9. θάρσει for θάρσει, οὐδὲς for οὐδεὶς.
L. 10. ἀθάτος for ἀθάνατος.

“One God, amen. Monument of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos, who ceased to live, having a good name, at the age of 30 years in the year 311, on the 30th of the month of Dystros, the 6th day of the Lord. Be of good cheer, no one is immortal.”

The text is built on one of the most usual patterns for the Christian funerary epigraphy from Zoora. After the opening monotheistic acclamation, the monument is individually assigned to the deceased, whose name is praised and whose death is precisely dated, before the inscription ends with the expected disillusioned formula

* Alain Desreumaux reviewed a draft of this article and gave us his suggestions on the bilingual Graeco-Aramaic epitaph. We would like to thank him for this, as well as the anonymous reviewers, on the understanding that we alone are responsible for any errors that may remain here.

1. Epigraphic corpus by MEIMARIS & KRITIKAKOU-NIKOLAROPOULOU 2005, 2008, and 2016 (hereafter abbreviated to *I. Zoora*): 384 Greek and 71 Jewish Aramaic epitaphs from late antiquity. Reviews: *BE* 2006, 492; 2009, 529; 2017, 615. On ancient Zoora, see most recently POLITIS 2020, 2021, and 2023.
2. BADER & HABASH 2012 and 2013; ZELLMANN-ROHRER 2019; KOKKINOS & POLITIS 2022; AL-RAWAHNEH & FONTANA ELBOJ 2022; KRITIKAKOU-NIKOLAROPOULOU 2023.



Figure 1 - Tombstone of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

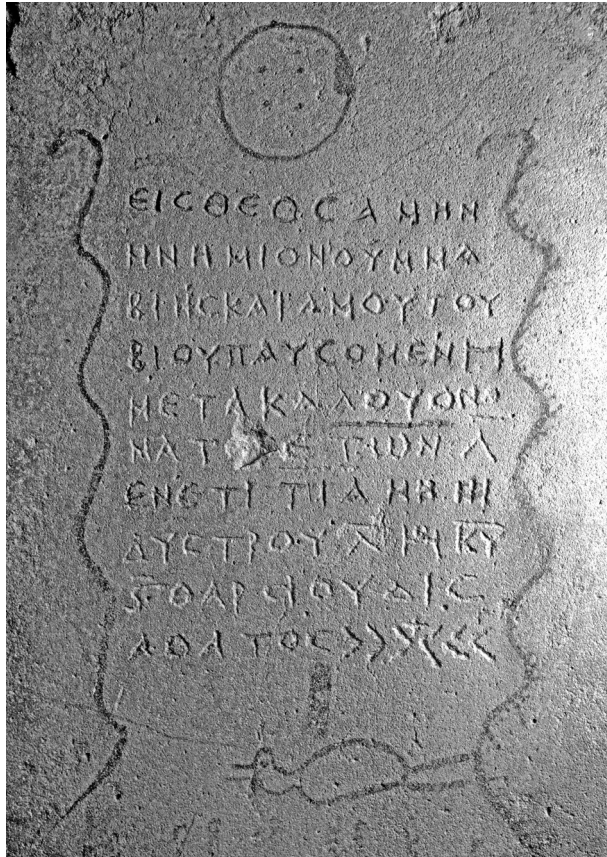


Figure 2 - Tombstone of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos: Greek epitaph. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

reminding mortals of their common fate. The date given here must be converted using the era of the Roman province of Arabia, which had been inaugurated in 106 AD and which still prevailed at Zoora as in the province of Palaestina Tertia in the early Byzantine period. The epitaph thus goes back to Friday, March 16, 417 AD.

The name of the deceased woman is part of the numerous series of anthroponyms that evoke kinship. It is based on the expression by which a person could refer to his paternal grandmother (“mother of my father”).³ If one looks for earlier parallels in the Roman Near East, it can be compared to the Palmyrene *’mby* and even more to the undeclined *Ομαβι* and *Ομμαβει*, which are already attested in the northern part of Provincia Arabia in the 2nd or 3rd century AD, according to Greek epitaphs from the area of Bostra and from Adraa.⁴ Such vocalizations point to an Arabic origin (أم أبي, *’umm-’abī*). Aramaic forms appear

in Greek as *Εμεδαβους*, *Εμδαβους*, *Εμμεδαβους*, *Ιμηδαβους*, *Ιμμεδαβου*, etc.⁵ Spellings similar to *Ομαβι* and *Ομμαβει*, but with endings, were also used in late antiquity at Hebron in Palaestina Prima (*Ωμαβις*⁶) as well as in the land of Moab (*Ομαβιη*⁷), at Sobota (*Ομαβις*⁸), and in the Wādī Haḡḡāḡ (*Ομμαβις*⁹) in Palaestina Tertia. The most numerous and diverse of these (*Ομαβιη*, *Ομμαβι*, *Ομμαβιη*, *Ουμμαβιη*, *Ωμμαβι*) have been found in Christian Greek epitaphs from Zoora, where there are two other examples with the same spelling.¹⁰ The necropolis of the city also yielded a Jewish tombstone whose Aramaic text refers to a certain *’Ummabī*, daughter of Simon (*’wmby brth dsymwn*).¹¹ As will be seen below, *Ουμμαβιη* is rendered with a slightly different (and rather surprising) spelling (*wm’by*) in the Aramaic version of our inscription. However, it is the same name, which could obviously be used by Jews and Christians in fifth-century Zoora.

The idea of a Hellenized Semitic anthroponym of possible Arabic origin also applies to the patronymic of Oummabie. *Καιαμος* and its variants (*Καιιομος*, *Καιουμος*, *Καιαμιος*) appear at least nine times in the epigraphic corpus of the city.¹² Without being specific to Arabia and the three Palestines, the names of this series were also common in these provinces in late antiquity. All of them are derived from the root QWM, “to rise, to stand, to last, to stay” (hence also “to resurrect”), in Aramaic and Arabic. According to their vocalization, they are related either to the qattāl form *qayyām*, “firm, steady” (*Καιαμος*, cf. Arabic *قيام*), or to the qattūl form *qayyūm*, “eternal, everlasting” (*Καιουμος*, cf. Arabic *قيوم*).¹³ In our epitaph, the two dots which are engraved on either side of the iota of *Καῖαμου* probably mark a dieresis to account for the doubling of the medial consonant of the name.

3. *I. Zoora* 1a, p. 132; AL-JALLAD 2017, pp. 166-167; YON 2018, p. 161.

4. *IGLS* 13/2, 9628 (*Ομαβι*), at al-Summāqiyyāt near Bostra; *IGLS* 14, 138 (*Ομαβι*), and 143 (*Ομμαβει*), in Adraa.

5. YON 2018, pp. 160-161. The particle *d* (as in Palmyrene *’mdbw*) and the vocalization are clear indication of the Aramaic character of those names. In *I. Zoora* 1b, 12, *Εμμεδαβους* must be interpreted as an undeclined feminine name; the participle following the patronymic *Μαρχιανοῦ* is not *παυσάμενος* (for *παυσσάμενου*), but *παυσσάμενης*.

6. *CIIP* 4, 3823.

7. Unpublished Greek Christian epitaph today kept in the store of the Department of Antiquities of Jordan at Ṭabarbur near ‘Ammān (K 7561).

8. ALT 1921, p. 43 no. 143.

9. *I. Wadi Haggag* 110 (to be corrected in the forthcoming *LGPN* 6).

10. *Ουμμαβιη*: *I. Zoora* 1a, 46 (384 AD), 242 (485 AD). Other forms: *I. Zoora* 1a, 34 (375/376 AD), 35 (375 AD), 89 (405 AD), 129 (425 AD), 311 (undated).

11. *I. Zoora* 1c, 56 (approximately dated to the first half of the fifth century AD).

12. *I. Zoora* 1a, 69, 106, 120, 171, 187, 191, 205; 1b, 34. See also *I. Zoora* 1a, 214 (feminine *Καιαμη*).

13. *I. Zoora* 1a, pp. 162-163, 296-297; GRASSI 2010, pp. 11-12; YON 2018, p. 197.

A thirteen-line Aramaic inscription is painted in 0.5 to 1.5 cm high red letters at the bottom of the tombstone (Figures 3-5). Turned 90° to the left in relation to the Greek version of the epitaph and aligned to the left on a long horizontal stroke extended by wavy lines in dotted and semi-circular patterns, it is framed by two tall crosses linked with rhos, left and right, and associated with a crudely depicted bird, which is also turned 90° to the left and whose legs are resting on the tail of the snake on the right. The choice was made to use the Syriac alphabet to transcribe vertically a text probably forged from the original Greek epitaph and written in another Aramaic dialect. Similarly, other signs evoke the handwriting practices associated with Syriac. Simple dots are added at the end of lines 5, 9, 11, and 13. At the bottom left, a group of four dots arranged in a diamond shape seems to mark the end of the text in the manner of a full-stop. All these signs are reminiscent of the punctuation marks already used in the rare fifth-century Syriac manuscripts.

The inscription remains difficult to read and interpret. Basically, it appears as an adaptation of the original Greek

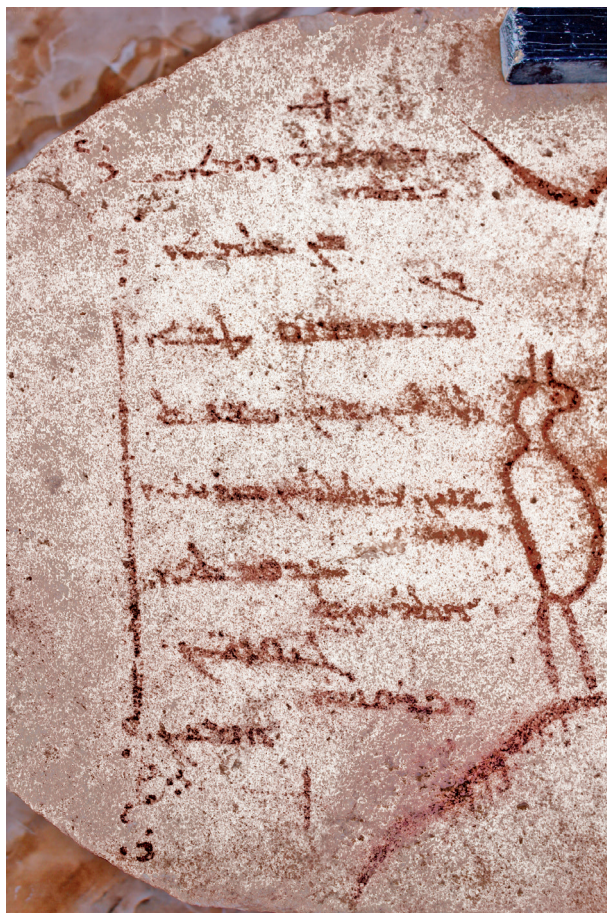


Figure 3 - Tombstone of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos: Aramaic epitaph turned 90° to the right. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

text of the epitaph, below which it was added using the free space on the stele. In its wording, the Aramaic version seems to follow the order of the Greek, but its layout is curious: not only is the size of the line spacing variable, but spaces are also left empty in lines 2-3 and 8-13 either on the left or on the right of the visible words. The idea of an aesthetic arrangement cannot be ruled out, as with the rubrication of the Greek text every four lines. However, the apparent blunders and quirks of syntax make one wonder whether some words are missing and whether they had been painted in a colour (green?) that would have held less steadily than red, although direct examination of the stone did not permit to discern traces of letters in the empty spaces. The design of the bird which is associated with the Aramaic version of the epitaph adds to the overall impression of oddity and incompleteness. The edition and translation that follow the diplomatic copy account for passages that may be missing by means of ellipsis.

<i>Diplomatic copy</i>	<i>Line</i>	<i>Edition</i>
ܕܟܪܘܢܗ ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	1	dkrwnh dwm'by
ܡܪܬܗ	2	brth ...
ܡܢ ܗܠܐ ܗܝܬ	3	... mn 'lm'
ܕܢ	4	d'n ...
ܡܡܫܡܢܘ ܬܒ'	5	wbmšmnw t̄b',
ܬܠܬܝܢ ܫܢܝܢ ܒܫܢܬ	6	tl̄tyn šnyn bšnt
ܫܢܝܢ ܒܬܠܬܝܢ ܒܝܪܗ	7	šnyn' btl̄tyn byrh'
ܕܪ	8	dr' ...
ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	9	... 'rwbt',
ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	10	'tr̄št ...
ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	11	... gywzyn,
ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	12	dkrwnh ...
ܕܡܡܝܒܝ	13	... 'myn.

Translation

- 1/ Memorial of Ummabī,
- 2/ his daughter...
- 3/ ... from this world
- 4/ ...
- 5/ and with a good name,
- 6/ thirty years old, in the year
- 7/ years(?), on the thirtieth of the month
- 8/ of...
- 9/ ... Friday.
- 10/ She had trust...
- 11/ ... passing away
- 12/ of her memorial...
- 13/ ... amen.

The following remarks draw attention to the difficulties of the inscription and to the parallels that can be found in contemporary Aramaic dialects of the southern Near

East, in particular Christian Palestinian Aramaic (CPA), in order to stress the discrepancy between the language of the Aramaic version of the epitaph and its script.

L. 1, *dkrwnh*: the Syriac form would be *dwkrn*; *dkrwn* is the form attested in CPA and in Jewish Palestinian Aramaic.¹⁴ Note the dot above the final *h*, which is expected in Syriac for a personal pronoun of the third person singular feminine and which appears again on the final *h* in line 12.

wm'by: as noted above in relation to the Greek version of the epitaph, this feminine personal name is well attested in Zoora. However, the spelling without initial *ā* *laph* seems odd and unattested, as opposed to *'wmby* of I. Zoora 1c, 56.

L. 2, *brth*: curiously, the patronymic of the deceased is absent here, whereas the expression “his daughter” implicitly refers to the father. Unless the patronymic was inscribed in the large blank space after this word, it can be assumed that another nearby stele bore the father’s name or that the Greek version of the epitaph is being referred to.

L. 4, *dn*: the reading of the demonstrative pronoun (more commonly spelled *dyn*) was suggested by A. Desreumaux;¹⁵ our first reading was *kn*, “here.” The dot of the *d* is not visible.

L. 5, *wbmšmnw tḇ*: this phrase would fit the Greek μετὰ καλοῦ ὀνόματος. The form *mšmnw*, from *šm* “name,” is not attested. A. Desreumaux suggested we read *wbhymnw tḇ*, “with good faith,” with an undetermined form of *hymnw* (cf. CPA Mt 17,20, and 21,21,¹⁶ to translate πίστεως). This proposal would be consistent either with the development of the full expression μετὰ καλοῦ ὀνόματος καὶ καλῆς πίστεως in many Greek epitaphs from Zoora (below, nos. 4 and 6),¹⁷ or with the few occurrences of the phrase μετὰ καλῆς πίστεως in the same necropolis.¹⁸ However, the reading adopted here seems more likely in view of the phrasing of the Greek version, of the available photographs, and of the direct examination of the stone. Since μετὰ καλῆς πίστεως καὶ καλοῦ ὀνόματος is also attested in Zoora,¹⁹ it is questionable whether *wbmšmnw tḇ* was written alone or whether these words were preceded at the end of line 4 by another expression referring to the good faith of the deceased. In any case, these formulas have no equivalent in the Jewish Aramaic epitaphs from the site.

L. 6, *syāmē* above *šnyn*.

L. 7, *šnyn* (apparently again with *syāmē*): following *šnyn bšnt* (“in the year”), which is written at the end of line 6, one would expect to read at the beginning of line 7



Figure 4 - Tombstone of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos: Aramaic epitaph, upper part turned 90° to the right. © Photo by Younis Al-Shdaifat 2022.



Figure 5 - Tombstone of Oummabie, daughter of Kaiamos: Aramaic epitaph, lower part turned 90° to the right. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

šy (𐤌𐤍), i.e. 311, to match the Greek ἐν ἔτι τῷ. The letters we read here (*šnyn*) may have been repeated by mistake. As suggested by an anonymous reviewer, an attractive interpretation would be to interpret *bšnt šnyn* as “in the year of years,” alluding to the age of death, 30, that is the age of Christ. Note also the *syāmē* above the *b* and the *t* of *bšntyn*.

Ll. 7-8: our first reading was *'* on line 7 and *dr* on line 8, interpreted as the name of the month of Adar (*'dr*). As pointed out by an anonymous reviewer, this is uncertain. It would be better to read line 7 *byrh* (construct state) and line 8 *d* (genitive particle), “in the month of,” perhaps followed by *r*. Nevertheless, the word *'dr* is expected here

14. SCHULTHESS 1903, p. 46; SOKOLOFF 1990, p. 150.

15. SCHULTHESS 1903, p. 47; SOKOLOFF 1990, p. 153.

16. SCHULTHESS 1903, p. 11.

17. I. Zoora 1a, pp. 25-26.

18. I. Zoora 1a, 181; 1b, 41.

19. I. Zoora 1a, 168 and 195.

as the usual equivalent of the Greek name of the month of Dystros.²⁰ The possible presence of a third character in line 8 is problematic. It raises once again the question of the completeness of the text that is now visible.

L. 9, *rwbt*: the word (for “Friday”) is also attested in CPA and Syriac; Jewish Aramaic epitaphs from Zoora have the phrase *ywm rwbth*.²¹

The reading of lines 10–12 still must be clarified. One would expect to find here an adaptation of the last words of the Greek version, *θάροσι, οὐδὲς ἀθάνατος*, “be of good cheer, no one is immortal.”

L. 10, *rhš*: “to trust, to rely,” with a similar meaning for the Gt (Ethpe’el) form *trhš*. The verb is commonly associated with the prepositions *b-* and *l*. According to *CAL*, it is attested in most of the Aramaic dialects (including CPA), but not in Syriac. This is a possible semantic equivalent of the Greek verb *θαρσεῖν*. One would have expected an imperative, but the final *-t* shows that the verb is conjugated here in the perfect tense, in the first person singular, in the second person masculine singular, or in the third person feminine singular. The latter interpretation would fit the feminine gender of the deceased: “she trusted” or “she had trust in.”

L. 11, *gywzyn*: a form of the verb *g(w)z*, “to go across” and, by derivation, “to pass away, to die,” which seems specific—with this meaning—to Palestinian Aramaic (e.g., CPA John 11,39).²² A single Jewish Aramaic epitaph from Zoora has *gz*, “he passed away.”²³ The meaning in Syriac is “to hasten away, to be lacking.” Alternatively, the *y* could be the final stroke of *g*. The reading adopted here was suggested by A. Desreumaux, but the sequence *yw* is not easy to explain. There are many forms without *w*. If the reading is correct, the grammatical analysis of the form *g(y)wzyn* is rather straightforward in CPA, where the *syāmē* are used for masculine plural forms.²⁴ The nearest form would be an imperative form in the plural, but that would make less sense. A hypothetical translation could be: “those who are dying/dead,” “those passing away.”

L. 12: The dot below the initial *d* is barely visible. If this letter were to be read as a *b*, as some photographs suggest, it would be tempting to see it as the preposition following the verb *rhš*. Another possible reading would

be *prqn*’ (Syriac ܩܪܢܐ, *prqn*’), “redemption,” a term well attested in the Targum or in CPA.²⁵

Until now, only one bilingual Graeco-Aramaic epitaph was known at Zoora.²⁶ According to the editors of the epigraphic corpus, this latter document was originally a Greek epitaph using the provincial era of Arabia, which would have been overlaid with Jewish symbols and accompanied by an Aramaic epitaph referring to the era of the destruction of the Temple and the Sabbatical cycle, to emphasize the deceased’s membership in the local Jewish community. The situation here is quite different. There are undeniable similarities with the Jewish Aramaic epitaphs from Zoora, whether one considers the vocabulary or the onomastics. Nevertheless, the most extraordinary fact is that the Aramaic version of Ummabī’s epitaph was transcribed using the Syriac alphabet and handwriting practices.

The script of our inscription has nothing to do with the square script of the Jewish Aramaic inscriptions from Zoora. It is also quite different from the CPA script, even though the latter is well attested in Palestine and Jordan. On the other hand, it is very similar to the estranghela script used in the Syriac epigraphic documents from northern Syria in the 5th century AD and later. As in many early Syriac manuscripts and inscriptions, the text is written vertically. Despite a possible blunder in line 7, its elegant and regular design betrays the hand of a scribe with a good command of the Syriac language and writing (*syāmē* indicating plural in lines 6–7, dots above letters to mark the feminine in lines 1 and 12, punctuation marks, etc.). In lines 4, 8, and 12, some *d* (ܕ) do not have the underwritten dots that distinguish them from *r* (ܪ). The *b* (ܒ) and *m* (ܡ) have a rectangular shape. The *w* (ܘ) are closed. The *t* (ܬ) is a closed semi-circle underneath a vertical stroke. A Syriac manuscript with a similar script is BL Add. MS 14512, dated 459/460 AD. The CPA manuscript Vat. sir. 19 is not very different in this respect, but it is much later (ca. 1030 AD) and, as often with CPA examples, its script is more square and rigid than in our inscription.²⁷

Chronologically, the epitaph of Ummabī/Oummabie is approximately contemporary with the oldest dated Syriac manuscript, the famous BL MS Add. 12150, whose colophon states that it was completed in Edessa in the year 723 (in the Seleucid era, i.e. 411 AD).²⁸ The oldest known Syriac inscriptions are also from about the same period.²⁹ By comparison, most of the CPA manuscripts are much later and their writing is said to be derived from estranghela or from a common ancestor with Syriac. The oldest known CPA inscription may be that of a mosaic

20. Josephus, *Jewish antiquities* 11, 107 (καλεῖται παρὰ μὲν ἡμῖν Ἰσάδωρ παρὰ δὲ Μακεδόσιν Δύστρος), and 12, 412 (τοῦ μηνὸς τοῦ λεγομένου παρὰ μὲν Ἰουδαίοις Ἰσάδωρ κατὰ δὲ Μακεδόνας Δύστρου); *IGLS* 17/1, 19 = *PAT* 2778 (Palmyra); GRUMEL 1958, pp. 173–174 (Antioch and Provincia Arabia).

21. *I. Zoora* 1c, 30, 35, and 38.

22. See SCHULTHESS 1903, p. 35.

23. *I. Zoora* 1c, 38. This meaning is not mentioned by SOKOLOFF 1990, p. 122. The Jewish Aramaic epitaph from Zoora is the only reference given by BEYER 2004, p. 368, for this word.

24. MÜLLER-KESSLER 1991, pp. 30–31, § 2.3.6.

25. SCHULTHESS 1903, p. 163.

26. *I. Zoora* 1c, 4 (= *I. Zoora* 1a, 18).

27. See HATCH 1946, pl. 2 (Syriac) and 198 (CPA).

28. HATCH 1946, pl. 1.

29. BRIQUEL CHATONNET & DESREUMAUX 2011.

from the church of ʿEvron in the territory of Ptolemais in Phoenice Maritima, which is thought to have been laid in 415 AD.³⁰ In any case, the CPA script had its own characteristics, as shown by the complete survey of epigraphic documentation drawn up by R. Hoyland in 2010, then revised and expanded by É. Puech in 2011 and A. Desreumaux in 2016.³¹ Only one inscription of unknown provenance could be compared to the epitaph of Zoora. Its first editor considered it quite old (“assez ancien”), based on the shape of the letters 𐤁, 𐤃 and 𐤄.³² The rounded *t* (𐤁) resembles the one in the epitaph from Zoora. However, the 𐤃, 𐤄, and square 𐤅 are taller and less elongated in the CPA inscription. At Zoora, the same letters are closer to those of the classical Syriac alphabet.

Despite the difficulties of reading and interpreting the Aramaic version of the new epitaph from Zoora, a few conclusions can be drawn. To date, the inscription on the funerary stele of Ummabī/Oummabie is one of the oldest documents to use the Syriac alphabet in the Near East. It is also an unexpected and early witness to the use of this script far south of the region where it originated in late antiquity. The use of the era of the Roman province of Arabia (also called the era of Bostra) is very rare in Syriac manuscript tradition, which gives an idea of the limited diffusion of the Syriac language in the southern provinces of the Near East. An early Syriac manuscript probably related to the Roman province of Arabia and Palaestina Tertia is dated from the year 427 in the era of Bostra, i.e. 532/533 AD,³³ more than a hundred years after the new epitaph of Zoora. In Jordan, only two Syriac inscriptions were known until now, dating from the end of the Umayyad period: both are due to the same Christian traveler who left his name and the trace of his passage in the black desert of the Ḥarra in mid-Lent of the year 744 AD.³⁴

Returning to Zoora, one may wonder why the Syriac alphabet was preferred when it came to transcribe the Aramaic adaptation of the Greek epitaph of Oummabie. As usual in cases of allography,³⁵ this was certainly not a default choice. At the beginning of the 5th century AD, the skills of

a scribe well versed in the practices of Syriac manuscript tradition were most probably used to enable a Christian family from Zoora to distinguish itself from the local Jewish community while at the same time displaying its Hellenism and its belonging to the Aramaic cultural world.

■ 2/ GREEK EPITAPH OF DIOTIMOS

The tombstone is made of purple sandstone. Almost oval, broken into two fragments, and chipped all around, it is currently 42 cm high, 27 cm wide, and 5.5 cm thick. No trace of paint or decoration is visible. The inscribed side has been smoothed to receive an eight-line Greek epitaph. The text is very erased in its central part, so that only the beginning and the end are readable. The letters are 2 cm high (Figure 6).

Μνημῖον
Διοτείμ[ου]
Ο[---]
4/ [---]
[---]
[---]
θάρσι, οὐδὶς
8/ ἀθάνατος.

L. 7. θάρσι for θάρσει, οὐδὶς for οὐδεὶς.



Figure 6 - Tombstone of Diotimos. © Photo by Younis Al-Shdaifat 2022.

30. JACQUES 1987; *CHIP* 5, 6084.

31. HOYLAND 2010; PUECH 2011; DESREUMAUX 2016. See also DESREUMAUX 2022.

32. MILIK 1953, pl. 18; HOYLAND 2010, p. 32.

33. See HATCH 1946, pl. 15.

34. GOREA 2005.

35. On allographic traditions through the ages, e.g., DEN HEIJER, SCHMIDT & PATARIDZE 2014 (synthetic reflections, case studies from late antiquity to modern times). See also YON 2007 (Graeco-Aramaica); BRIQUEL CHATONNET 2015 (Garshuni); BRIQUEL CHATONNET 2017 (Phoenician-Punic world); AL-JALLAD 2017 (Graeco-Arabica); MESSMER 2022 (western middle Aramaic); ALIQUOT, GATIER, HAWLEY & YON 2022 (Graeco-Aramaic dossier from the Tomb of the Founder of Capitolias in Bayt Ra's, northern Jordan).

“Monument of Diotimos... Be of good cheer, no one is immortal.”

The Greek name of the deceased was not known in Zoora until now. Although theophoric anthroponyms built on the name of Zeus are frequent in the Near East, Διότιμος is rare in all periods, even in Phoenicia where there are only a few early mentions.³⁶

■ 3/ GREEK EPITAPH OF IOANNES, SON OF KLAUDIOS

The tombstone is made of white brownish sandstone. Almost rectangular in shape and broken in the upper left corner, it is 28 cm high, 19 cm wide, and 7 cm thick. On the front side, a Greek epitaph of thirteen lines is engraved in 1.5 cm high letters, within a rectangular field 23 cm high and 13 cm wide. Lines 1, 2, 4, 7, 10, and 13 are also highlighted with red paint (currently only in part for line 1). Horizontal strokes appear above the abbreviated divine name in line 1 and above numerals in lines 8-9. A series of simple crosses open and close the text: only one at the beginning of line 1, five at the end of line 13. The inscription is fully preserved (Figure 7).

- † Εἰς Θ(εο)ς ὁ βοηθ-
 ὦν. Μνημῖον
 Ἰωάννου Κλαυ-
 4/ δίου, ἀποθανο-
 ύντος μετὰ κα-
 λοῦ ὀνόματος
 ἑτῶν α', ἐν ἔτι
 8/ τπς', ἐν μην(νι) Ἀρτ-
 ημεισείου η',
 ἐν ἡμέρᾳ πα-
 ρασκευῆς, θάρ-
 12/ σι, οὐδὲς ἀθάν-
 ατος. †††††

L. 2. μνημῖον for μνημεῖον. Ll. 4-5. ἀποθανολύντος for ἀποθανόντος. L. 6. ὀνόματος for ὀνόματος. L. 7. ἔτι for ἔτει. Ll. 8-9. Ἀρτημεισείου for Ἀρτεμισίου. L. 10. ἡμέρᾳ for ἡμέρᾳ. Ll. 11-12. θάρσι for θάρσει, οὐδὲς for οὐδεὶς.

“One God who helps. Monument of Ioannes, son of Klaudios, who died having a good name at the age of 1 year, in the year 386, on the 8th of the month of Artemisios, on Friday. Be of good cheer, no one is immortal.”

The epitaph is dated Friday, April 28, 490 AD. The names of the deceased baby and his father are both very common and well attested in Zoora. Ἰωάννης, a Christian



Figure 7 - Tombstone of Ioannes, son of Klaudios. © Photo by Younis Al-Shdaifat 2022.

name of biblical origin, is by far the most popular name in the late antique Near East.³⁷ Κλαύδιος is the Latin *gentilicium Claudius*. It is quite commonly used as a single name in the region corresponding to Provincia Arabia, including Zoora and the whole Palaestina Tertia.³⁸

■ 4/ GREEK EPITAPH OF MOSALEMOS, SON OF KASSIANOS

The stele is today kept in Mutah University. Made of white brownish sandstone, roughly trapezoidal in shape, and broken at the top and in the left and right sides, it is currently 35 cm high, 33 cm wide, and 8.5 cm thick. On the front side, a Greek epitaph of twelve lines is engraved in 0.8 to 1.5 cm high letters, within a rectangular field 22 cm high and 21 cm wide, bounded on the left by a green line and on the right by a red line. The first line is centred.

36. See *IGLS* 11, p. 118.

37. See *I. Zoora* 1a, p. 152; 1b, p. 124.

38. See *I. Zoora* 1a, p. 149; 1b, p. 115.

In addition, the letters are enhanced with paint according to a succession of four times three lines highlighted in red, green, and white respectively. Horizontal strokes appear above the numerals and the abbreviated divine name in lines 8-10. Below the text is a green cross inscribed in a red circle with a diameter of 3 cm, between the symbolic letters omega and alpha painted in red. The trace of a vertical red palm branch is also visible to the left. The inscription itself is fully preserved and easily readable (Figure 8).

- Εἷς Θεός.
Μνημῖον Μοσα-
λεμος Κασσιαν-
4/ νοῦ, ἀπαθανόν-
τος μετὰ καλοῦ
ἀνάματος καὶ
καλῆς πίστεως,
8/ ἐτῶν ν', ἣν ἔτι
τκζ', ἐν μηνὶ Ἀρ-
τεμυσίου γ', ἡμ(έρα) Κ(υρίο)υ
ἔκτῃ, θάρσι, οὐδι-
12/ ς ἀθάνατος.
ω † α

Ll. 2-3. μνημῖον for μνημεῖον; Μοσαλεμος undeclined instead of Μοσαλεμου. Ll. 4-5. ἀπαθανόντος for ἀποθανόντος. L. 6. ἀνάματος for ὀνόματος. L. 8. ἣν ἔτι for ἐν ἔτει. Ll. 9-10. Ἀρτεμυσίου for Ἀρτεμίου. L. 10. The abbreviation of ἡμ(έρα) is in the form of a mu with a small eta on top instead of an eta with a small mu on top. Ll. 11-12. θάρσι for θάρσει, οὐδὶς for οὐδεὶς.



Figure 8 - Tombstone of Mosalemos, son of Kassianos. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

“One God. Monument of Mosalemos, son of Kassianos, who died having a good name and good faith at the age of 50 years, in the year 327, on the 3rd of the month of Artemisios, the 6th day of the Lord. Be of good cheer, no one is immortal. Omega and alpha.”

The epitaph is dated Friday, April 23, 432 AD. The names of the deceased and his father were already known in Zoora. Μοσαλεμος is derived from the root SLM (cf. Arabic مُسَالِم, *musālim*, “peaceful”).³⁹ Κασσιανός is the Latin *cognomen* *Cassianus*.⁴⁰

5/ GREEK EPITAPH OF PHASELE, DAUGHTER OF OBEDAS

The tombstone is made of pinkish white sandstone. Almost rectangular in shape, 37 cm high, 28.5 cm wide, and 13 cm thick, it is cut in a rather crude manner and chipped at the top right-hand corner and at the bottom left-hand corner. The back of the monument is rounded. On the front side, a Greek epitaph of nine lines is engraved in 1.5 to 2.5 cm high letters below a cross linked to a rho and above another cross. Red paint is still visible in the letters of line 1. The inscription is easy to read, although a little faded in places (Figure 9).

- Μνημῖον
Φασηλη Οβε-
δα, ἀπαθανόν-
4/ τας ἐτῶν ιη',
ἔτους σνα', μη(νὶ)
Ἀρτεμυσίου ε',
θάρσι, οὐδὶς ἀ-
8/ θάνατος, vac.
ἡμέρα Ἡλίου.

L. 2. Φασηλη undeclined instead of Φασηλης. Ll. 3-4. ἀπαθανόντας for ἀποθανόντος instead of the expected feminine participle ἀποθανούσης. L. 7. θάρσι for θάρσει, οὐδὶς for οὐδεὶς.

“Monument of Phasele, daughter of Obedas, who died at the age of 18 years, in the year 251, on the 5th of the month of Artemisios. Be of good cheer, no one is immortal, on Sunday.”

The epitaph is dated Sunday, April 25, 356 AD. The Hellenized Semitic names of the deceased young woman

39. *I. Zoora* 1a, 251. See also *I. Jordanie* 2, 120 (Μοσαλεμος in Madabā, 179/180 AD); *I. Jordanie* 5/1, 686 (Μοσελεμος in al-Dafyāna); GATIER 2020, pp. 130-131, about Μοσαλεμος, Μοσελεμος, Μοσλεμος, Μουσλιμ, etc., and their respective counterparts in Nabataean (*mšlm*) and ancient North Arabic (*ms'lm*) inscriptions.

40. *I. Zoora* 1a, 142, 182, 232.



Figure 9 - Tombstone of Phasele, daughter of Obedas. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

and her father are well known in Zoora. Φασηλη is the Greek transcription of *fš'lpš'l*, “the god (’l) has released, set free.”⁴¹ This theophoric epicene name has already appeared six times in the city, where it is also spelled Φασελη.⁴² According to a series of graffiti from Petra, it was given to a daughter of the Nabataean king Aretas IV (9/8 BC-40 AD), which may explain its popularity in Arabia and Palestine. The patronymic Οβεδας also recalls royal Nabataean onomastics and corresponds to the Arabic عبيد (*ubayd*). It is attested at least twice in Zoora.⁴³ The father of a Sosanna buried in the city cemetery in 360/361 AD could be identical to the person mentioned here.⁴⁴

41. See SARTRE 1985, p. 242, *I. Zoora* 1a, pp. 186-187, and NORRIS 2017, pp. 95-98, for occurrences of the name in Semitic inscriptions (Nabataean, Safaitic, Hismaic) and spelling variants in the Greek epigraphy of Arabia and Palestine.

42. *I. Zoora* 1a, nos. 92, 147 (Φασηλη); nos. 116, 210, 225, 296 (Φασελη).

43. *I. Zoora* 1a, no. 20 (Οβεδας); 1b, no. 22 (genitive Οβεδδου).

44. *I. Zoora* 1a, no. 20: μνημιον Σωσαννα Οβεδας, dated in the year 255 of the era of the province of Arabia.

6/ GREEK EPITAPH OF THE SON OF SAMAKON

The tombstone is made of white brownish sandstone. Almost rectangular in shape, it is broken at the top and in the lower left corner. Its dimensions are unknown. On the front side, a Greek epitaph of at least eleven lines is engraved. Red paint is still visible in the letters of lines 3, 6, and 9. We also noticed the presence of S-shaped signs before and after numerals in line 7, of horizontal strokes above numerals in lines 8-9, and of two crosses in line 11 at the end of the text. Only the first three or four lines of the inscription are lost. All the rest is easily readable (Figure 10).

[--- Σαμα]-
κωνος, ἀποθανόν-
4/ τος μετὰ καλοῦ ὁ-
νόματος <καὶ> καλῆς
πίστεως, ἐτῶν
νε', τοῦ ἐν ἔτι
8/ τλζ', μηνὶ Ξαν-
θικοῦ εἰ', θάρσι,
οὐδὲς ἀθάνα-
τος. † vac. †

L. 5. καὶ omitted. L. 7. τοῦ ἐν ἔτι for ἐν τῷ ἔτει. L. 9. θάρσι for θάρσει. L. 10. οὐδὲς for οὐδεὶς.

“... son of Samakon, who died having a good name and good faith at the age of 55 years, in the year 337, on the 15th of the month of Xanthikos. Be of good cheer, no one is immortal.”

The epitaph is dated April 5, 442 AD. The name of the deceased is not preserved. His patronymic Σαμακων can be restored here with a high degree of probability. Although it is not very common, it has already been recorded five times in Zoora.⁴⁵ This Hellenized Semitic name may be derived from the root SMQ, “to be red,” rather than from the root SMK, “to prop up, to support.”⁴⁶

45. *I. Zoora* 1a, 23, 24, 102; 1b, 29 (ΑΣμακων for Σαμακων); unpublished Greek epitaph of Samakon, son of Sabinos, which is now kept in the store of the Department of Antiquities of Jordan at al-Karak (K 7383). Apart from Zoora, the name is only found at 'Evron in the territory of Ptolemais in Phoenice Maritima (*CIIP* 5, 6083, 6088, 6090, and 6096) and perhaps in the abbreviated form Σαμα(κων) at Archelais near Jericho (*CIIP* 4, 2672).

46. YON 2018, p. 174. Cf. maybe *smqy*, name of a priest of a monastery near Damascus, according to the Syriac “Letter of the archimandrites of Arabia” (570 AD), ed. by CHABOT 1907, p. 221, line 29. A connection with the name *smq* of the Safaitic inscriptions seems less likely. On this name: HARDING 1971, p. 359, from Arabic شَمَق, “to be foolishly merry.”

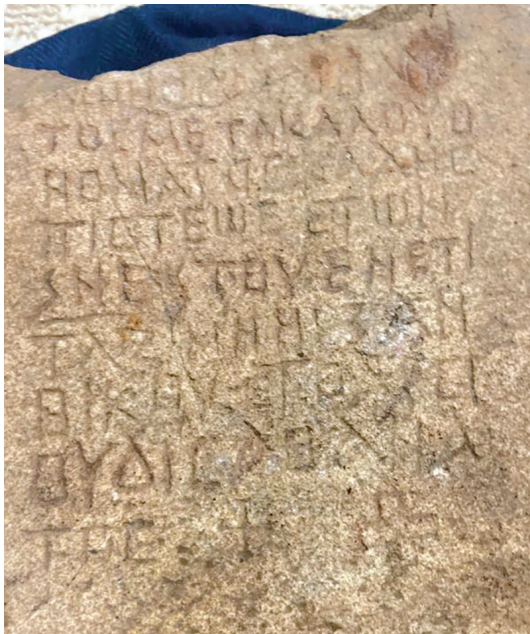


Figure 10 - Tombstone of the son of Samakon. © Photo by Younis Al-Shdaifat 2022.

7/ FRAGMENTARY GREEK EPITAPH

The stele is made from a barely rough pebble of pinkish white sandstone 43 cm high, 28 cm wide, and 7.5 cm thick. Only the front face was smoothed to receive a Greek epitaph of about twelve or thirteen lines. In the upper part, where one would expect to find the name and patronymic of the deceased, the inscription seems to have been intentionally erased using a pick. This may be an attempt to recycle an earlier stone in late antiquity.⁴⁷ In the middle section, the only section to have survived, it is carefully engraved in 0.5 to 1 cm high letters, with horizontal strokes above numerals. Below, it stops abruptly at the end of a line and in the middle of the word οὐδὲς. The end of the text may have been painted only, but this remains uncertain as there are no traces of colour anywhere (Figure 11).

[- ca. 5 lines -]
 [---] ἀπο-
 θανόντος ἐ-
 4/ τῶν κ', ἔτο-
 υς τριακοσσί-

47. For examples of stelae erased and re-inscribed, e.g., *I. Zoora* 1a, nos. 15, 29, 166, and 268. Simple hammering: *I. Zoora* 1a, 205.

ους θι', ἐν μηνὶ
 Περιτίου θ',
 8/ θάρσι, οὐ-
 vac.

Ll. 5-6. τριακοσσίλους for τριακοσίους in place of τριακο-
 σιοστοῦ. L. 8. θάρσι for θάρσει.

“..., who died at the age of 20 years, in the year 319,
 on the 9th of the month of Peritios. Be of good cheer,
 no...”

The epitaph is dated January 24, 425 AD.



Figure 11 - Tombstone for an anonymous deceased. © Photo by Julien Aliquot 2023.

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■ ABBREVIATIONS

- BE "Bulletin épigraphique", in *Revue des études grecques*, Paris, 1888-.
- CAL *Comprehensive Aramaic lexicon* (<https://cal.huc.edu/>).
- CIIP *Corpus inscriptionum Iudaeae/Palaestinae*, Berlin, 2010-.
- I. Jordanie *Inscriptions de la Jordanie*, Paris/Beyrouth, 1986-.
- I. Wadi Haggag NEGEV 1977.
- I. Zoora MEIMARIS & KRITIKAKOU-NIKOLAROPOULOU 2005, 2008, and 2016.
- IGLS *Inscriptions grecques et latines de la Syrie*, Paris/Beyrouth, 1929-.
- LGPN *Lexicon of Greek personal names*, Oxford, 1987-.
- PAT HILLERS & CUSSINI 1996.

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